

Company case

ASICS Advertising and PR in the era of social media
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It was raining outside and ASICS' director of integrated marketing communication was thinking about what it would be like to go for a run as he looked out from his office on the 10th floor; after all, those committed to the sport would not let a little rain stop them. Running was on his mind as the company needed to meet the goals of its five-year strategic plan after a drop of 70 per cent in its second quarter earnings. More specifically, America's sales had dropped 22 per cent, while Europe grew 4 per cent. He knew that a focus on the performance running market had to be one of the priorities to reach the company's strategic goals, but how? The brand had a reputation for producing high-quality technical gear, but it had not done a good job in creating an emotional connection with the consumers.

Running in the UK and USA

Let's not fool ourselves, running is tough and it hurts. At the same time, more than 2 million people run at least once a week in the UK and 10.5 million run frequently in the USA. Why do people do it? One reason is practical in nature. Running is relatively easy to fit into modern life, as all you need is a good pair of shoes and you can do it in any environment. In other words, it is easier to fit into one's schedule. In fact, running has been growing in popularity since the 1960s. However, convenience is only part of the story; a closer look at the sport reveals a richer set of reasons behind running's increased popularity in recent years. Runners run to stay healthy, get fit or lose weight – this is true particularly when they start to run. For many the reason is deeper rooted – it has to do with performance, such as running faster or further. For many people performance sports are a personal goal and relief from everyday stresses.

So who are runners? Let's start with the term 'runner', because it is important. The majority of the runners will define themselves as 'runners' rather than 'recreational joggers' (who run less) or 'competitive runners' (who are elite athletes). In the committed running community, to be referred to as a jogger is a bit of an insult, 'I run, I don't jog' is a common answer to those that refer to a runner as a jogger. Runners will run regularly, all year round, regardless of the weather. Something makes them want to run. An article from *Runners World*, a leading running

magazine, can in fact recall 52 reasons to run a marathon. In the table below, the top seven on this list are shown, and they are not just about fitness.

Table 1 The top 7 reasons to run a marathon

1. Exuberance – The marathon is mythical. While you can get an amazing high from tackling any race distance, conquering the mother of all races gives you a high which is hard to duplicate.
2. Inspire others – Doesn't matter if you are speeding to a PR, crawling to the finish, or anything in between, someone on the sidelines is going to start running soon because of seeing you pushing through this distance.
3. Self-confidence – That whole conquering the beast thing above? Yeah, with that slayed, daily tasks will seem simple by comparison. If you could bottle the self-confidence you have after finishing a marathon and sell it, you'd be a billionaire.
4. Be a superhero – Ever seen those Heatsheets blankets you get when you are done? Go ahead and try not to feel like Superman when they put those around your neck.
5. Travel – We always find excuses not to spend money to see the world. But throw in a marathon and you have given yourself a reason to check out small pockets you never would have allowed yourself to go to before.
6. Learn the most of an area – Once you are on the course, even if it is in a small town in the middle of nowhere, there is no better way to learn an area than on foot. Seeing 26.2 miles of it without worrying about turn signals is the best way possible.
7. Make new friends – As we get older, the places and chances to meet new people become less and less. On a marathon course, you don't have to think of small talk or a way to break the ice. You know you are both going through this together.

Source: *Runners World*

Runners are well off: 75 per cent of runners earn more than \$50,000 a year. They are educated with a white-collar job. They enter races of various distances, such as 10Ks (10 km), half-marathons (13.1 miles), marathons (26.2 miles) and ultras (anything above 26.2 miles). Runners come in all shapes and sizes. It is not just a young person's sport; the number of runners over 40 years of age is indeed growing; the male to female ratio in races is about 50/50.

Table 2 Running preferences

Where do people run?	Run on trails	37%
	Run on roads	64%
Will bad weather stop a runner?	Run outside during harsher weather	57%
	Run inside during harsher weather	43%
How many runners run listening to music?	Run with music	60%
	Run without music	40%

Source: Running USA

Running, as it turns out, is not a cheap sport either. Footwear and performance clothing, sport watches, nutrition, race fees, etc. all soon add up. Running is mainly a solitary activity, however it doesn't have to be always so. Some will also join running clubs, including virtual running clubs. Races, both those with thousands of participants and smaller local ones, are very much a social affair. Online, the connection continues. Runners follow brands and race organisers in social media as well as bloggers and elite runners. Four in ten share running-related experiences in social media. Technology is part of the running experience, as the majority of runners will track their mileage via an app and/or GPS watches.

All in all, the running market looks attractive, competitive and complex. ASICS has to find a way to break through the clutter and find a way to connect, also emotionally, with their current and potential customers.

'I Move Me' campaign

ASICS is an acronym for 'Anima Sana in Corpore Sano', an old Latin phrase for 'a sound mind in a sound body'. A message that seems to reflect perfectly the meaning of modern running, particularly distance running. However, the brand has been struggling of late and in an effort to inject new life into the brand, the 'I Move Me' global rebrand campaign by Saatchi & Saatchi LA was launched in 2017. This has been the most significant for the ASICS brand since 1992.

The campaign ran (pun intended) across 13 markets in EMEA with over 1,000 items of curated content created to reach over 400 million people; similar to the creative activities that ran in the USA market. In this geography, the content was developed by brand communications agency SUPERLARGE, in line with the global 'I Move Me' campaign. The 'I Move Me' campaign spans across all areas of the business in true integrated fashion, in fact, it is brought to life by a newly established Integrated Marketing Communications team at ASICS. Their remit sounds simple, but it is complex in its implementation. The aim is to provide a seamless brand experience across all touchpoints. The campaign brings together the products and the brand in a unifying message from the brand, which celebrates high-quality products matching personal movement and achievements.

The campaign puts inspirational characters at its core with a series of videos and related content that tell the human stories of athletes. These athletes come from a cross-section of society and each one has his or her inspirational running story to tell. They talk about how movement has affected their lives, helped them overcome challenges or societal judgement; it further talks about what running has given them in terms of happier and healthier lives. For example, ASICS Europe presents a video featuring Food and Lycra, online influencers who challenge Instagram retouched visions of beauty and unhealthy relationships with food. Their video tagline is 'I don't move for beauty norms. I Move Me'. Another video features Susie Chan, an endurance runner who has taken part in some of the toughest ultra-marathons; she talks about how running changed her life and made her a better parent as well as helping her become mentally strong. ASICS America features a video with the DJ Steve Aoki, who talks about the changing nature of life and the need to follow his inspiration.

Digital is at the heart of this campaign but it develops via multimedia, such as advertising on Eurosport, print, outdoor advertising, ASICS events and ASICS frontrunners brand ambassadors. Print includes ads and features in running magazines such as *Runners World*. ASICS continues to sponsor key marathons. In the UK, for example, these include the Manchester marathon, which attracts over 9,000 runners of all abilities, many hoping for a personal best time given the flat and fast course. ASICS also sponsors the Windermere marathon; this race has a challenging hilly course and a smaller number of runners tackling the challenge. Last year ASICS acquired RunKeeper, a fitness tracking app to support the effort of runners. The ASICS brand ambassadors, called ASICS Frontrunners, are carefully selected runners from among thousands of applicants, that embody the spirit of the brand and share it in their social media activities. Again, runners of different abilities and overcoming various challenges through running are selected, not only the fast ones. Finally, retail is another key brand communication channel. More flagship stores have been opened or are planned to open in London, New York and Tokyo. Throughout all these different expressions, the brand message is consistent and almost seamless in execution.

The railway issue

With such a sophisticated global branding campaign, all seemed to move in the right direction and the attention to detail was noted in leading marketing magazines such as *Marketing Week*, *PR Week*, etc. However, on the evening of 4 November 2018 something unexpected happened on Twitter. One of ASICS UK's campaigns featured people running down a disused train track. The images are beautiful and the runners in them appear strong. The pictures are indeed compositionally appealing: the track lines framed the runner nicely and communicated the idea of the distance/going far. However, runners on Twitter took a very different view 'This ad is wrong on so many levels (. . .) it is

irresponsible (. . .)'; 'This ad shows total disrespect for safety' were some of the comments that appeared. Users tagged ASICS UK and also Rail Safety Week, and the British Transport Police were alerted to the ads. Runners thought that these types of ads were irresponsible, given the dangerous location and the recent trend of taking selfies on train tracks with at times fatal consequences. Furthermore, some even commented that running on the tracks simply isn't realistic; of all the surfaces one may wish to run on, a train track seems quite an unlikely one and at best a trip hazard.

Initially ASICS' Twitter account was quite defensive on the matter, responding that the featured train track was indeed disused so no safety regulations were breached. Screenshots also circulated, which showed that ASICS had updated its profile to show photos with images involving said train tracks in response to the (arguably uncalled-for) criticism. Since then, however, the railway track posts and marketing material have been removed from the official ASICS presence, due to the rising criticism, which continued for several days. The removal of the material helped somehow to deal with the problem, even if in the eyes of the influencers and runners online who witnessed this exchange the brand is still suffering from the initial mistake and the way it was dealt with.

Questions for discussion

- 1 What were the objectives of the 'I Move Me' campaign? And how do you critically evaluate these objectives?
- 2 Describe the creative concept developed by Saatchi & Saatchi LA for ASICS and discuss the execution styles applied to the creative concepts in the videos and related print ads. You can search for them online and/or follow the links in the sources below.
- 3 Do you agree with the media choices made by ASICS to deliver the campaign? Why? What are the advantages and disadvantages of each?
- 4 Research 'ASICS FrontRunners' on social media such as Twitter or Facebook. How can they help generate UGC about the ASICS brand? Critically discuss the positive and negative influences that social media can have on a brand's PR efforts.
- 5 To what extent did the railway video/images incident cause problems for the ASICS brand? Do you think ASICS should have anticipated the issue, and why?

Source: 'National Runner Survey 2017', *Running USA*, http://cdn.trustedpartner.com/docs/library/RunningUSA2012/RunningUSA_NRS_2017.pdf; 'Children "taking selfies" on rail tracks as trespassing doubles', BBC News, 18 July 2018, <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/uk-wales-44863173>; ASICS, 'Campaign "I MOVE ME"', *PR Newswire*, 21 March 2018; Jim Avila, Gitika Kaul and Serena Marshall, 'The dangers of taking photos on train tracks', ABC News, 17 October 2015, <https://abcnews.go.com/US/dangers-taking-photos-train-tracks/story?id=34533140>; Vybarr Cregan-Reid 'Why running is fast becoming the most popular way to exercise', *Independent*, 30 May 2016, <https://www.independent.co.uk/life-style/health-and-families/why-running-is-fast-becoming-the-most-popular-way-to-exercise-a7056481.html>; Larry Eder, 'Asics launches "I Move Me" a global rebrand, most significant since 1992', *RunBlogRun*, 2 August 2017, <http://www.runblogrun.com/2017/08/asics-launches-move-me-a-global-rebrand-most-significant-since-1992.html>; Adharanand Finn, 'Why we love to run', *Guardian*, 5 February 2013, <https://www.theguardian.com/lifeandstyle/the-running-blog/2013/feb/05/why-we-love-to-run>; <https://www.asics.com/gb/en-gb/frontrunner/how-to-apply>; <https://www.brathaychallenges.com/events/running/marathon>; <https://www.foodandlycra.com/>; <https://www.runnersworld.com/women/a20799856/52-reasons-to-run-a-marathon/>; <https://youtu.be/kPG8lOX5bO8>; <https://youtu.be/p6jfbOdH4HU>; <https://youtu.be/rgsG5fjAR64> and <https://youtu.be/wC20K6ol8Lc>; Andrew Papworth, 'ASICS advert showing people doing star jumps on railway removed after police criticism', *East Anglian Daily Times*, 8 November 2018, <https://www.eadt.co.uk/news/british-transport-police-east-anglia-criticises-asics-uk-advertising-campaign-1-5770279>; Brad Stulberg, 'Why do rich people love endurance sports?' *Outside*, 3 August 2017, <https://www.outsideonline.com/2229791/why-are-most-endurance-athletes-rich/>; 'Long distance running – the state of the sport', *USA Track & Field*, 2018, <http://www.usatf.org/news/specialreports/2003ldrstateofthesport.asp>; Sarah Visard, 'Asics in biggest brand shakeup in 25 years as it looks to broaden appeal', *Marketing Week*, 7 August 2017, <https://www.marketingweek.com/2017/08/04/asics-biggest-brand-shakeup-25-years-looks-broaden-appeal/>; Beth Wright, 'Asics unveils new action plan as Q2 profit slumps 70%', *Just-style*, Research News, Analyst Report, 7 August 2018, https://www.just-style.com/news/asics-unveils-new-action-plan-as-q2-profit-slumps-70_id134187.aspx, accessed May 2019.